sensors, heavyweight torpedoes and anti-ship missiles, and the nuclear-capable Babur-3 cruise missiles. The leap in endurance gives Pakistan the ability to operate far from home and delivers a second-strike option.

Admiral Sunil Lanba (retd), former Chief of the Naval Staff, believes that if the Hangor submarine has the necessary range, a deployment in the Bay or the eastern Indian Ocean would be feasible. However, its effect would be limited unless it can undertake an operational turnaround at a port. "We would need to assess how many of these submarines are operationally available and the most likely areas of their deployment. If one considers the possibility of a Hangor being deployed off a harbour on the east coast, then anti-submarine operations would need to be intensified in that area," says Adm. Lanba.

Vice Admiral A.K. Singh, a former submariner, agrees with Lanba and observes that such deployments are possible only if Pakistan secures refuelling provisions in Bangladesh. However, he does believe that it would take the Pakistan Navy years to master the operational availability and reliability of the Hangor-class for long-range deployments.

The port most likely to help the Hangors out, feel Indian military experts, is BNS Pekua, Bangladesh's easternmost naval base, near Cox's Bazar. If Pakistan were granted access to the base for turnaround, it would substantially extend the Hangors' time on patrol. However, such a port visit would make it easy for India to track a sub's movement. It would lose surprise and stealth—arguably a submarine's greatest strengths.

The possibility of Pekua being made available to Pakistan is not far-fetched, given the remarkable thaw in Dhaka-Islamabad ties since the fall of the Sheikh Hasina regime in 2024. Diplomatic and military exchanges have increased, along with broader defence cooperation. In November 2025, Pakistan Navy frigate PNS *Saif* docked at Chattogram—the first visit by a Pakistani warship to Bangladesh since 1971. Bangladesh and Pakistan also participated in the joint exercise AMAN, held in the North Arabian Sea in February 2025.

Such exchanges suggest a gradual expansion of defence ties without implying a formal alignment. The strategy dovetails with China's 'String of Pearls' approach to expand influence around India.

DARK WATER RIVALS

A comparison of the submarine capabilities of India, China and Pakistan



INDIA

Nuclear-Powered Ballistic Missile Submarines (SSBN)

Numbers: **2** *(INS Arihant, INS Arighat with INS Aridaman under construction)*

First inducted in 2016, they can deliver intercontinental nuclear ballistic missiles

After the return of the leased INS *Chakra* to Russia, India has no Nuclear Attack Submarine (SSN) for conventional operations. Delivery of another leased SSN, INS *Chakra III*, is delayed. There are plans to build two SSNs under Project 77

Diesel Electric Submarines (SSK)

Numbers: **6**

Kalvari-class (Scorpene-class)

Built with France and inducted in 2017, there are plans to build three more with Air-Independent Propulsion (AIP) technology. Older ones to be retrofitted with AIP. Has Exocet anti-ship missiles, MICA anti-air missiles



Note: Talks are in an advanced stage to build three SSKs in India with advanced AIP with German firm TKMS under Project 75(I)

Shishumar-class

Numbers: **4**

German-origin subs ideal for anti-surface, anti-submarine warfare, have good endurance. Armed with Harpoon anti-ship cruise missiles

Sindhughosh-class (Kilo-class)

Numbers: **7**

Russian-origin attack submarines inducted from 1986. Can launch anti-ship cruise missiles



"If one considers the possibility of a Hangor being deployed off a harbour on the east coast, then anti-submarine operations would need to be intensified in that area"

ADMIRAL SUNIL LANBA (RETD), *Former Chief of the Naval Staff*

THE MIGHTY MEDDLER

China is Bangladesh's primary partner in naval modernisation. Under the Forces Goal 2030 initiative, Beijing supplied two Type 035G Ming-class diesel-electric submarines and built the BNS Pekua submarine base, which was inaugu-